Bodily Generation in Performing Arts and Performance and Its Correspondence to the Five-Stage Model

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1. Purpose and Questions of the Investigation

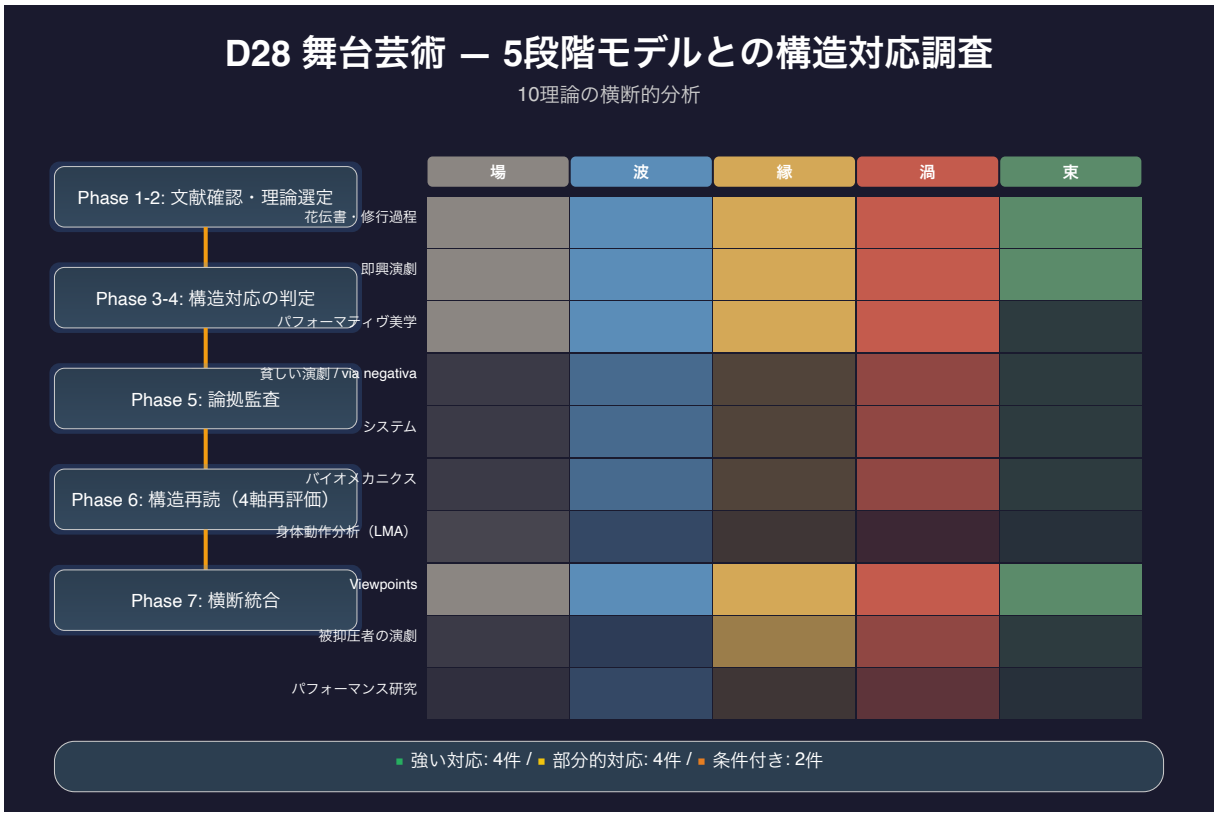

Figure 1: Bodily Generation in Performing Arts and Performance and Its Correspondence to the Five-Stage Model —

This report was prepared to answer the following question:

> Do the various theories in this academic domain correspond structurally to the five-stage model (Field ( ) -> Wave ( ) -> Edge ( ) -> Vortex ( ) -> Bundle ( ))?

It systematically evaluates the structural resemblance between generative processes mediated through body, action, and attention and the five-stage structure. The coexistence of the singularity of each performance and long-term discipline is a distinctive feature of the performing arts, and this is a domain in which the boundary with the audience, relations among performers, and the interface between body and space form multilayered Edges.

This report is an account of the investigation's results; it is not a document written to justify any particular theory. Areas where the correspondence is strong and areas where reservations are necessary are described with the same degree of neutrality.

2. Method of Investigation

Scope and Selection Criteria

In this domain, 10 theories and practical models were selected for evaluation. The selection was based on three criteria: (1) the theory explicitly addresses processes of generation or transformation; (2) structural analysis is possible on the basis of primary sources or well-established secondary sources; and (3) different lineages within the domain can be compared.

Evaluation Method

For each theory, the report first explains what the theory describes and then examines where correspondences with the five stages can be identified. Judgments of correspondence were made by considering together the concepts found in the texts, concrete examples, connections between stages, the presence or absence of a cycle from Bundle to the next Field, and the risk of forced interpretation.

Criteria of Judgment

- **Strong structural correspondence**: The core concepts of the theory correspond concretely to multiple stages of the five-stage model, and the report can explain why this is so in the main text.
- **Conditional correspondence**: A correspondence can be indicated, but interpretive reservations remain in mapping the stages.
- **No correspondence confirmed**: Partial approximations exist, but the theory cannot be read without strain as exhibiting the structure of the five stages as a whole.

Limits of the Investigation

This investigation is not an exhaustive examination of every work associated with each theory. It focuses on the core concepts of major works and extracts structures at a level of granularity that permits comparison. Accordingly, there are places where the internal details of a theory or historiographical disagreements within scholarship could not be fully addressed.

3. Overview of the Model

The five-stage model describes the creative process in terms of the following five stages.

Stage	Definition
Field	An undifferentiated state. It refers to initial conditions in which neither direction nor structure has yet been determined.
Wave	A stage of exploration in which multiple directions diverge and differences are amplified.
Edge	A stage of tension in which opposing elements coexist and do not immediately converge on either side.
Vortex	A stage in which a new coherence or order emerges out of tension.
Bundle	A stage in which form becomes determinate and stabilizes as a reusable structure.

This model is not a one-way line but includes a cycle in which Bundle becomes the condition for the next Field. Moreover, the five stages are not strictly separated boxes but are understood as a continuous spectrum. The model includes the hypothesis that the same structure can recur at different scales, from momentary thought to institutional formation to long-term historical change.

If a sense of incongruity remains at this point, that itself is an important concern of the present investigation. Readers may continue with that sense of incongruity still intact.

Figure 2: Bodily Generation in Performing Arts and Performance and Its Correspondence to the Five-Stage Model — ×5

4. Results of the Investigation: Overall Picture

List of Theories Evaluated

Theory	Proponent	Structural Correspondence
Zeami's treatises on flower and the training process (practice -> mastery -> flower)	Zeami Motokiyo (c.1400-1418)	Strong
Improvisational theatre (Johnstone / Spolin / Nachmanovitch)	Johnstone (1979), Spolin (1963), Nachmanovitch (1990)	Strong
Fischer-Lichte's aesthetics of performance (autopoietic feedback loop)	Fischer-Lichte (2004/2008)	Strong
Grotowski's poor theatre / via negativa	Grotowski (1968)	Strong
The Stanislavski system	Stanislavski (1936/1949/1961; Benedetti trans. 2008-2010)	Strong
Meyerhold biomechanics	Meyerhold (1920s-1930s)	Strong
Laban Movement Analysis (LMA / Effort-Shape)	Laban (1947/1950), Bartenieff	Conditional
Viewpoints Bogart / Landau	Bogart & Landau (2005); original conception: Mary Overlie (1970s)	Strong
Boal's Theatre of the Oppressed	Boal (1974/1979)	Strong
Schechner's performance studies	Schechner (1977/1985/2002)	Conditional

Of the 10 items evaluated, 8 showed strong structural correspondence, 2 showed conditional correspondence, and 0 failed to show any confirmed correspondence. Overall, this domain exhibits correspondence with the five-stage model at a comparatively high density, but the manner of correspondence is not uniform. Some theories offer a thick description of the conditions of the Field, while others describe with precision the tensions of the Edge or the fixation of the Bundle.

What is especially important is not the high rate of correspondence in itself, but rather which theory describes which stage and in what vocabulary. Even when this domain addresses the same topic of creativity, different layers, such as body, institution, time, perception, practice, and symbol, illuminate different moments of the five stages.

5. Results of the Investigation: Examination of Major Theories

5.1 Zeami's treatises on flower and the training process (practice -> mastery -> flower)

In Zeami Motokiyo's (c.1400-1418) treatises on flower and the training process, Zeami's *Fushikaden* (c.1400-1418) describes the training process of Noh in terms of stages of age (from seven years

old to old age), discussing the essentials of practice at each stage and the waxing and waning of "hana" (flower) as an aesthetic effect. It sharply distinguishes "jibun no hana" (the flower of the moment, a temporary charm) from "makoto no hana" (the true flower, an essential flower acquired through training). As *Fushikaden* states, " "; flower is an aesthetic effect generated from freshness, that is, from the difference between expectation and actuality, and it arises not as a fixed attribute but relationally and dynamically.

The correspondence of the training process to the five stages is clear. In particular, the description of "hana" as arising relationally and dynamically corresponds with precision to the structure of the Edge, in which something undetermined takes form within a network of relations. The transition from "jibun no hana" to "makoto no hana" corresponds to the transition from Wave to Vortex, that is, from surface fluctuation to structural integration. "riken no ken" is a cognitive structure by which totality is grasped within self-organization, and it corresponds to the self-referentiality of the Vortex.

This is a fifteenth-century Japanese theory of Noh. It took shape under the influence of Zen Buddhism, especially Rinzai Zen, and Tendai hongaku thought. As a discourse on the performing arts of the Muromachi period, it emerged from a cultural ground in which art and discipline were not yet differentiated. It belongs to the same body of texts as D30 (traditional performing arts and crafts) #3, "Ichiza Konryu," but in D28 the focus is on the training process, from practice to improvement to the emergence of flower, whereas D30 focuses on the communal formation of the troupe. Cross-reference is essential.

5.2 Improvisational theatre (Johnstone / Spolin / Nachmanovitch)

In improvisational theatre as developed by Johnstone (1979), Spolin (1963), and Nachmanovitch (1990), Keith Johnstone's *Impro* (1979) presented the concepts of status transactions, spontaneity training, and offer/block/accept. Viola Spolin's *Improvisation for the Theater* (1963), a foundational pedagogical method for improvisational theatre, developed techniques of theatre games, "focus," and side coaching. Her work grew out of Neva Boyd's research on recreational games.

The improvisational process is a compressed real-time enactment of the five stages. An offer appears on an empty stage (Field -> Wave), relational connection is formed through "Yes, and…" (Edge), an unexpectedly coherent scene emerges in a self-organizing way (Vortex), and successful patterns crystallize into games or formats (Bundle). This correspondence is tied at each stage to specific practical actions, and the structural resemblance is high.

Distinctive features that remain are as follows. (1) There is an explicit prohibition on planning. Whereas other creative processes do not necessarily exclude planning, improvisation methodologically requires that the movement from Field to Vortex arise without prior plan. In this respect, it most purely embodies the non-teleological character of the five stages. (2) "Yes, and…" functions as an operational definition of Edge. It makes the abstract cluster of relational network, indeterminacy, and connection toward Vortex practicable in a single phrase. This current belongs to the twentieth-century movement of theatre education and improvisational art. Spolin developed it from game research in Chicago settlement houses. Johnstone developed it independently in Britain and Canada. Nachmanovitch theorized it across the arts from the standpoint of musical improvisation. In recent years, improvisational theatre has also been applied increasingly in organizational development and design thinking.

5.3 Fischer-Lichte's aesthetics of performance (autopoietic feedback loop)

In Fischer-Lichte's aesthetics of performance as articulated by Fischer-Lichte (2004/2008), Erika Fischer-Lichte's *Ästhetik des Performativen* (2004; English translation: *The Transformative Power of Performance*, 2008) argues that meaning generation in performance occurs not through

semiotic representation but through bodily co-presence (leibliche Ko-Präsenz). It replaces the conventional aesthetic concept of the "work" with that of the "event." The autopoietic feedback loop is the loop of interaction arising between performers and spectators through which the performance generates itself. The outcome is not decided in advance but generated within the loop.

The autopoietic feedback loop is a theoretical refinement of Edge, and the correspondence with the five-stage model is supported by concrete concepts at each stage. In particular, the transition mechanism from Edge to Vortex, from feedback loop to emergence, is precisely the central proposition of Fischer-Lichte's theory and accords with the core of the five-stage model. Her concept of "fluctuation" provides a precise description of Wave.

Distinctive features that remain are as follows. (1) The concept of liminality refines the experiential aspect of the Vortex, namely the dissolution of everyday categories and the experience of transformation, in terms drawn from social anthropology. It shows that Vortex is not merely structural integration but entails a transformation in the mode of being of participants. (2) The use of the concept of autopoiesis contains a tension specific to this theory. The autopoiesis of Maturana and Varela as a closed system differs from Fischer-Lichte's notion of self-generation as an open system. This difference suggests that the Edge of performance is not a closed but an open system. This work stands within the German tradition of Theaterwissenschaft. It integrates Austin and Searle's speech-act theory, Turner and van Gennep's concept of liminality, and phenomenology, especially Merleau-Ponty. While running alongside postdramatic theatre theory (Lehmann), it concentrates on the aesthetic dimension. It is a foundational text for twenty-first-century performance studies.

5.4 Grotowski's poor theatre / via negativa

In Grotowski's poor theatre / via negativa as formulated by Grotowski (1968), Grotowski's *Towards a Poor Theatre* (1968) argues that actor training consists in removing resistance or blocks to the psychophysical process. Its methodological core is not the accumulation of skills but the eradication of obstacles, via negativa, the negative way. The goal of training is the simultaneity of impulse and action. To abolish the time lag between inner impulse and outer action is the aim. A state in which impulse and action are separated is a block, and the state in which this separation is resolved is the "total act."

In this theory, correspondence with the five stages can be observed through the movement by which preconditions are formed, differences are amplified, relations are organized, a new coherence emerges, and it settles into a stable form.

Distinctive features that remain are as follows. (1) It presents a methodology of creation through negation, that is, through subtraction. Whereas many other theories of creation presuppose addition or accumulation, Grotowski argues that integration appears as a result of removal. This compels a correction to any interpretation that reads the movement from Field to Bundle as additive progression. The transition from Field to Bundle may occur not through accumulation but through the dismantling of existing structures, whereby an essential structure is exposed. (2) His later "Art as Vehicle" excludes the spectator and closes transformation within the action itself. This suggests that Edge is not limited to relations with an external other. This work belongs to the experimental theatre and theatre anthropology of the later twentieth century. It stands in the lineage of Stanislavski (#5), but criticizes Stanislavski's "emotion recollection" and places direct bodily impulse at the center. It also forms a contrast with Meyerhold's (#6) biomechanics. Whereas Meyerhold moved from outer form to inner state, Grotowski moved from inner impulse to outer form. Yet both share the structure of a dialectic between form and content. Through Barba (Odin Teatret), Grotowski influenced theatre practice around the world.

5.5 The Stanislavski system

In the Stanislavski system associated with Stanislavski (1936/1949/1961; Benedetti trans. 2008-2010), Stanislavski referred to the actor's creative process as "taiken" (perezhivanie =), and placed at the center of the actor's art not the external imitation of a role but its inner experience. In his later period, this developed into the "Method of Physical Actions," a shift toward an approach in which outward action evokes inward life. The "if" (magic if / esli by) is the device by which the hypothesis "if I were in this situation" drives the actor's imagination and action. It creates a productive tension between reality and fiction.

In this theory, correspondence with the five stages can be observed through the movement by which preconditions are formed, differences are amplified, relations are organized, a new coherence emerges, and it settles into a stable form.

Distinctive features that remain are as follows. (1) The "if" indicates, as the reverse operation of D2, the deliberate production of predictive discrepancy. Whereas D2 concerns the detection of spontaneously arising absence or gap, the "if" intentionally produces discrepancy by positing a fictional situation. This is a technique for artificially generating Wave. (2) The concept of tempo-rhythm gives a precise account of the oscillatory character of Wave. The claim that a mismatch between inner and outer rhythm is perceived as falsehood concretizes the mechanism by which predictive discrepancy is detected. This work belongs to Russian theatre from the late nineteenth to the early twentieth century. It developed through practice at the Moscow Art Theatre, founded in 1898. Grotowski (#4) stands in Stanislavski's direct lineage but criticized "emotion memory" and centered bodily impulse. Meyerhold (#6) was Stanislavski's pupil, yet opposed to his teacher's line of "experience" a line of "construction." The English-speaking reception passed through the Hapgood translations (1936-1961), though their divergence from the originals has often been noted; the Benedetti translations (2008-2010) were published as a revised corrective. "Method acting" (Strasberg) is an extreme development of only one part of Stanislavski.

5.6 Meyerhold biomechanics

In Meyerhold biomechanics as developed by Meyerhold (1920s-1930s), Meyerhold's biomechanics, from the 1920s onward, was a system for training the actor's body as a machine. It pursued an "outside-in" approach in which inner states are generated from external movement, in contrast to Stanislavski's "inside-out" orientation. The reflex-arc model, intention -> realization -> reaction, constructs action as a three-stage arc. This three-stage structure is the basic unit of biomechanics.

The reflex-arc model (intention -> realization -> reaction) expresses in condensed form the transition from Wave to Edge to Vortex. Rakursi, the compression of all elements into a single point, is a concrete bodily expression of Vortex. The outside-in approach reverses the direction of Grotowski's inside-out approach, but the point of arrival, the integration of inner and outer as Vortex, is the same. This shows that the structure of the five stages does not depend on the direction of causality.

This work arose within the Soviet Russian avant-garde of the 1920s and 1930s under the influence of Constructivism and mechanistic thought. Meyerhold was a disciple of Stanislavski (#5), but set against his teacher's line of "experience" a line of "construction." Grotowski (#4) attempted to integrate Meyerhold's "construction" with Stanislavski's "experience." After Meyerhold's execution in 1940, biomechanics survived underground through his students and was reevaluated after Perestroika. Film director Eisenstein, known for montage theory, was also one of Meyerhold's students.

5.7 Laban Movement Analysis (LMA / Effort-Shape)

In Laban Movement Analysis (LMA / Effort-Shape) as associated with Laban (1947/1950) and Bartenieff, Rudolf Laban (1879-1958) developed a systematic framework for describing and analyzing human movement, Laban Movement Analysis (LMA). Its principal components are Body (what moves), Effort (how it moves, through the four factors of Weight, Time, Space, and Flow), Shape (how the body changes form), and Space (where movement occurs within the kinesphere). Effort describes the qualitative aspect of movement through four factors, Weight = light/strong, Time = sudden/sustained, Space = direct/indirect, and Flow = bound/free. Each factor is a spectrum on a continuum rather than a binary opposition.

The correspondence here is partial. Description of movement quality through the four factors of Effort provides a precise vocabulary for Wave, and the kinesphere is a bodily concretization of Field. Labanotation is a clear example of Bundle in the sense of symbolization and institutionalization. However, the structural correspondence with the five stages as a whole is weak. LMA describes what is happening, but it does not describe the process by which it comes to happen.

What remains distinctive is that LMA functions less as something translated into the vocabulary of the five stages than as a descriptive language for articulating the stages from the standpoint of bodily movement. Its value lies not in being a process model but in being a descriptive tool. This work belongs to dance studies and movement analysis in the first half of the twentieth century. Laban, born in Hungary, worked in Germany and Britain and was a central figure in Ausdruckstanz. Later, Bartenieff developed the framework in the context of dance therapy, and LMA has since been applied widely in dance education, rehabilitation, ergonomics, theatre training, and related fields.

5.8 Viewpoints Bogart / Landau

In Viewpoints Bogart / Landau as presented by Bogart and Landau (2005), with the original conception by Mary Overlie in the 1970s, Viewpoints was an improvisational and compositional method developed by choreographer Mary Overlie through the Six Viewpoints, Space, Shape, Time, Emotion, Movement, and Story, and later adapted to theatre by Anne Bogart. The major Viewpoints in Bogart's version are Tempo, Duration, Kinesthetic Response, Repetition, Shape, Gesture, Architecture, Spatial Relationship, and Topography. "Soft focus" is a perceptual state in which visual attention is not fixed on a particular object but diffused across the whole space. It is a foundational technique for grasping overall movement and relations simultaneously.

The practical process of Viewpoints corresponds clearly to the five stages. In particular, the sequence from soft focus to kinesthetic response to a spatial network of relations to the emergence of a theatrical moment to composition implements, as concrete procedure in actor training and creation, the process Field -> Wave -> Edge -> Vortex -> Bundle. While sharing a common basis with improvisational theatre (#2), it adds the spatial dimension and the transition from improvisation to composition.

Distinctive features that remain are as follows. (1) "Soft focus" is a perceptual technique of Field. Whereas Field in other entries is described as a state, Viewpoints provides a concrete perceptual operation for entering Field. (2) "Composition" explicitly sets out the mechanism of transition from Vortex to Bundle. It includes the process by which improvisational discoveries are converted into structured works. This approach developed from postmodern dance of the 1970s, associated with Mary Overlie and Judson Dance Theater, into theatre practice of the 1990s, associated with Bogart and SITI Company. The integration of Tadashi Suzuki's method (SCOT) with Bogart's Viewpoints formed part of SITI Company's methodology. Its emphasis on spatial composition also resonates with postdramatic theatre theory (Lehmann).

5.9 Boal's Theatre of the Oppressed

In Boal's Theatre of the Oppressed as proposed by Boal (1974/1979), Augusto Boal's *Theatre of the Oppressed* (1974/1979) redefined theatre as a means of social transformation. Under the influence of Paulo Freire's *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*, it criticized the passivity of the audience and proposed the concept of the spect-actor. Forum Theatre is the practice in which, in response to a scene depicting an oppressive situation, a spectator cries "Stop!," comes onto the stage, takes the place of the oppressed character, and attempts a different outcome. It dismantles the spectator-performer boundary and explores solutions collectively.

The process of Forum Theatre corresponds structurally to the five stages. In particular, the transition from the intervention of the spect-actor (Edge) to the emergence of a collective solution (Vortex) is precisely the core characteristic of Forum Theatre: unplanned emergence from within a network of relations. "Conscientization" can be read as the social dimension of D2, namely the recognition of the gap between a reality taken to be natural and a reality that is possible.

Distinctive features that remain are as follows. (1) This is the only entry that implements the five stages as the creation and transformation of social reality. It finds the five stages not in personal or artistic creation but in the collective process of transforming social structures. (2) There is the problem of the binary opposition oppressed/oppressor. This stands in tension with the non-dual presupposition of the five stages. In Boal's framework, the oppressor is externalized, but in the later Rainbow of Desire he also addresses internalized oppression as "the cop in the head," and the binary opposition is partially dissolved. This work belongs to Brazil in the 1960s and 1970s. It developed together with Freire's critical pedagogy under military dictatorship. Through Boal's exile from 1971 to 1986, it spread worldwide. It is one of the sources of Applied Theatre and also influenced TIE (Theatre in Education) and Theatre for Development. Its interdisciplinarity with sociology, political science, and education is especially strong.

5.10 Schechner's performance studies

In Schechner's performance studies as articulated by Schechner (1977/1985/2002), Richard Schechner was one of the founders of Performance Studies. He did not limit performance to theatre but defined it as a "broad spectrum" including ritual, play, sports, and everyday action. He established the Department of Performance Studies at the NYU Tisch School of the Arts. "Restored behavior" (twice-behaved behavior) means that every performance is behavior performed a second time, a repeated reenactment of past behavioral patterns. Yet repetition is never perfectly identical; each repetition includes difference.

Correspondences are clear at the level of individual concepts: broad spectrum (Field), restored behavior (Wave), transformation (Vortex), and the institutionalization of Performance Studies (Bundle). In particular, restored behavior as twice-behaved behavior provides an anthropological description of Wave in its claim that repetition always includes difference. The distinction between transportation and transformation illuminates the branching condition of whether the five-stage process ends at temporary fluctuation, that is, transportation at the level of Wave, or reaches structural change, that is, transformation at the level of Vortex.

Distinctive features that remain are as follows. (1) The broad-spectrum definition of performance supports the view that the five stages are applicable beyond the frame of the performing arts to all forms of human action. Schechner argues that any action can be analyzed as performance, while this report argues that creation in any domain proceeds through five stages. This parallel deserves attention. (2) The distinction between transportation and transformation offers a perspective from which to ask under what conditions the five-stage process is completed, reaching Vortex, and under what conditions it stops midway and returns after Wave. This work emerged from the interdisciplinary intersection of American theatre studies and cultural anthropology

from the 1960s onward. Schechner was also a theatre practitioner through The Performance Group (1967-1980) and developed Environmental Theater. His dialogue with Turner on ritual liminality formed part of the academic foundation of Performance Studies. Fischer-Lichte (#3) independently constructed an aesthetics and theory of performance, but Turner served as a shared point of reference. Boal's (#9) Theatre of the Oppressed can also be included within Schechner's framework of Performance Studies.

6. Cross-Cutting Patterns

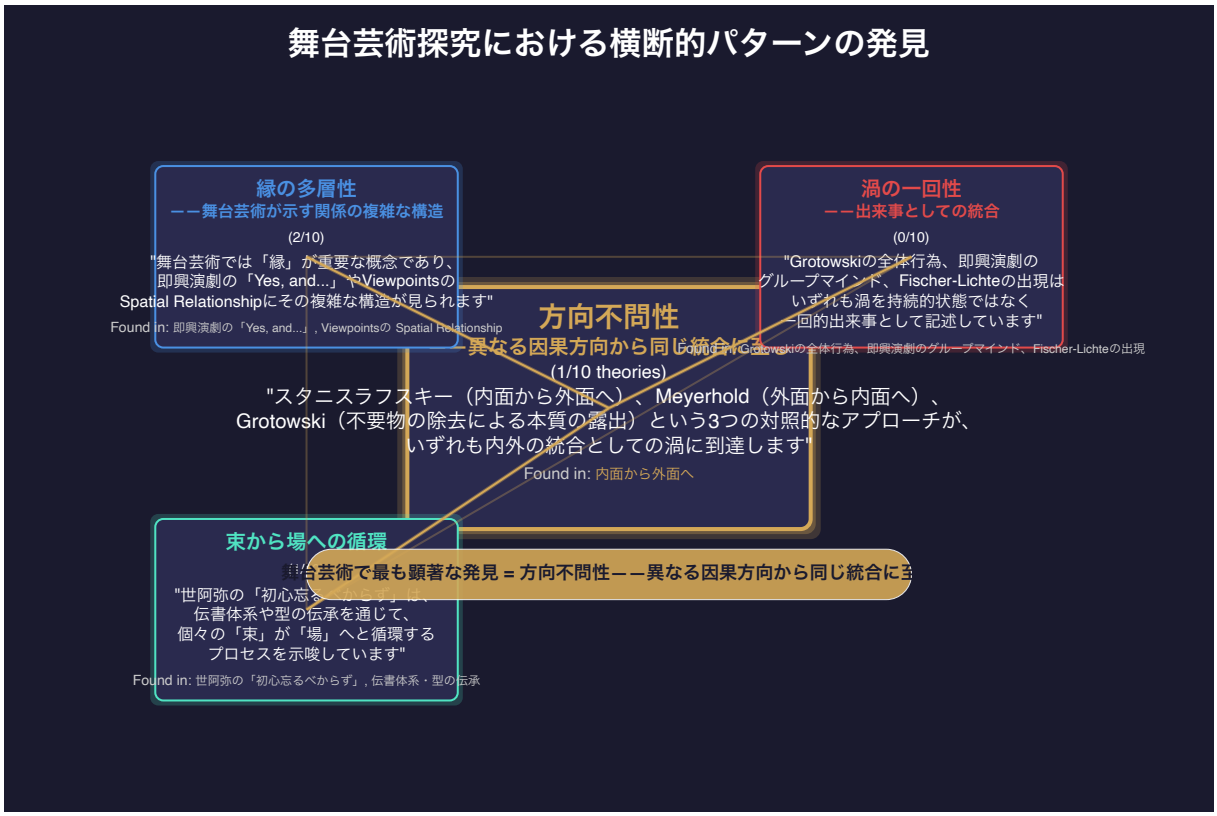

Figure 3: Bodily Generation in Performing Arts and Performance and Its Correspondence to the Five-Stage Model —

First, as shown by Zeami's treatises on flower and the training process (practice -> mastery -> flower), improvisational theatre (Johnstone / Spolin / Nachmanovitch), and Fischer-Lichte's aesthetics of performance (autopoietic feedback loop), this domain describes difference and opposition not merely as obstacles but as conditions for the emergence of a new order. This means that, among the five stages, the transition from Edge to Vortex can be observed here with particular richness.

Second, what Grotowski's poor theatre / via negativa, the Stanislavski system, and Meyerhold biomechanics share is that generation is not a one-off event but includes a cycle of forming preconditions, amplifying tension, producing local ordering, stabilizing it, and proceeding to the next reconfiguration. This confirms that the five-stage model must be read not as a static table of classifications but as a temporal movement.

By contrast, Laban Movement Analysis (LMA / Effort-Shape) and Schechner's performance studies also show that correspondence with the five stages is not established automatically. A shared number of stages or a resemblance in vocabulary is not sufficient. It is necessary to examine case by case which concepts bear the points of transition and at what level the structure arises.

7. Unresolved Questions

1. To what extent can Laban Movement Analysis (LMA / Effort-Shape) and Schechner's performance studies be read as descriptions of the stages of the five-stage model?
2. To what extent can the structures confirmed in this domain be extended from the explanation of individual cases into a more general model of generation? The conditions under which comparability can be preserved without losing the specificity of the objects still require closer examination.
3. Should the five stages be read as a linear progression, or rather as a cycle including multiple temporal layers and repetitions? In particular, theories differ in how explicitly they describe the return from Bundle to the next Field.
4. What becomes visible, and what is lost, when the vocabulary specific to this domain is replaced by the general vocabulary of the five stages? The boundary between what is translatable and what is not is itself an important issue for future comparative investigation.

8. Conclusion

This reconsideration of the domain confirmed strong structural correspondence in 8 of the 10 theories and conditional correspondence in 2. In particular, Zeami's treatises on flower and the training process (practice -> mastery -> flower), improvisational theatre (Johnstone / Spolin / Nachmanovitch), and Fischer-Lichte's aesthetics of performance (autopoietic feedback loop) provide especially rich descriptions of the movement from Field to Edge, or from Edge to Vortex, and therefore occupy a central place as evidence within this domain.

At the same time, the findings of this domain do not support the claim that the same five stages simply appear unchanged in every theory. The stages that appear most strongly differ from one theory to another, and in some cases reservations are necessary in mapping the stages. What matters, therefore, is not to generalize directly from a high rate of correspondence, but to continue comparing which moments are described in which vocabulary.

In that sense, this domain does not merely support the validity of the five-stage model in a single direction; it is also a domain that imposes conditions on how the model should be read. The very coexistence of theories that correspond densely and theories that require reservation constitutes the value of the comparative investigation.